

How I did it

The story of Manish Sabharwal, founder of hiring firm TeamLease

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We'd heard a lot about directory services available over the phone. As the not-so-old legend has it, JustDial is just a phone call away. 8888888 got prefixed with the 2 we're all so familiar with in India. As business grew, they got

a new number 69999999. In case you're unable to remember the number, you're probably amnesiac! The next time you read this, you can find a doctor by calling JustDial rightaway or simply log on to www.justdial.com.

We met VSS Mani, Managing Director of JustDial. He's been asked about his remarkable journey through the years several times over, that he candidly confessed

he'd rather not talk about it. The reason, he says is that "it slows you down." "Continuously pondering over the past can be dampening. So I'll just tell you in brief about our journey and focus more on what we plan to do in the future," he adds. Keeping the long story short, he was born in a middle-class Tamil family based in Kolkata, completed his higher education in Delhi, before coming to Mumbai. He began his journey in 1989, by founding a company called Ask Me, which was also a directory service.

Fate had him on the wrong side of the tracks and he found himself slightly ahead of his time. After running the show for close to three years, Mani gifted his share of the business to his partner and shut shop.

Determined to start again and more importantly to succeed this time around, he returned to the *City of Dreams* in 1994. He recalls how people who heard of his service Ask Me, were unable to recall its

phone number. This was the first lesson Mani learnt. In his comeback, he told himself he wasn't going to bother about the name, but rather on the number. A couple of years later in 1996, Mani heard of a new telephone series in Kandivli, Mumbai. The exchange code was 888. That was it. He immediately met the MTNL General Manager and explained his business plan. As Mani puts it, "probably the guy was a good person who saw the honesty in me". Without any further questions, the General Manager allotted him the number. Not entirely convinced that it was just that simple, Mani asked him if he could give it in writing!

After taking his word at face value, Mani applied for the number and was assigned 888 8888. JustDial was born. The service was launched after setting up an office with borrowed furniture and computers.

Mani hasn't looked back ever since. On an average, JustDial.com has grown on an average of 55 to 60 per cent per year. In fact, despite investments by some prominent venture firms such as Sequoia Capital, JustDial hasn't utilised the invested capital yet. It has been a self-driven journey so far.

Sandipan Chattopadhyay, CTO, JustDial was equally enthusiastic of the way things connect at JustDial. He shared confidently that although he is the CTO of the company, he believes if their technology (read interface) is too complicated, then they have failed as a company.

An alumni of the Indian Institute of Statistics, Sandipan is *not* the typical nerdy professor you would encounter – he's absolutely enthusiastic and passionate about the data he handles. His passion for the numbers behind JustDial was quite evident in his eyes as he spoke. Incidentally, he's the brain behind financial portal moneycontrol.com.

Several professionals had written them off saying their model wouldn't work and that they'd need Oracle's database platform to handle the complex nature of their data. It was interesting to note how they were proven wrong by Mani when analysing data. For those of you who might be wondering, they run their enterprise on open source software. Their database with millions of records runs on MySQL and their terminals run on a customised



You no longer have to run around hunting for directory services. With Just Dial you're never out of reach of your answer